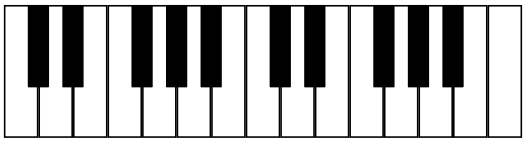
Read at Sight

A graded sight-reading course for piano

Volume 6 - Reading Like a Professional



Middle C

Three voices, cross-rhythms, changing meters and chromatic harmony; songs on three staves, open score with C clefs, lead sheets, and transposing and simplifying at sight.

Exercises generated to graded rules; pieces are original or public domain.

How to use this book

What is new in Volume 6

Volumes 1-5 taught you to read piano music. This volume teaches you to read music written for anyone: three-voice counterpoint, two rhythms at once, meters that change bar by bar, chromatic harmony, big textures, a singer's line above the piano, open score with alto and tenor clefs, and lead sheets with chord symbols. It also teaches the professional's two survival skills: simplifying at sight (dropping notes without losing the music) and transposing at sight. Start this book when you have passed the Volume 5 checkpoint: every key, triplets, the pedal, clef changes and ornaments.

The five rules

1. Never stop: keep the beat going, even after a wrong note. 2. Count out loud and use a metronome at the speed shown. 3. Keep your eyes on the music, not your hands. 4. Read the shape: up, down, or the same, and by how much. 5. Play each exercise once, tick its box, and move on. Come back only after a few weeks.

Before every exercise: 10 seconds

Name the key (or mode) and the time signature, and check whether either changes. Count the staves and name each clef. Find the hardest bar and decide what you will drop from it if you must. Then count one bar in and play.

How each unit is laid out

A unit opens with what is new, short examples, and reading tips. Parts A to C are generated exercises that practise the new idea. The pieces come next: real music by the great composers, chosen because each needs exactly the unit's new skill. A checkpoint ends the unit.

A daily routine (15-20 minutes)

Warm up with the scale and the main chords of the day's key (2 minutes). Read 4-6 new exercises, one pass each (8 minutes). Then read one piece, or a page of one, keeping the beat and simplifying where you must (8 minutes).

Contents

Each unit adds exactly one new idea to everything before it.

Unit 1 Three Voices 4
Three independent voices on two staves; the middle voice passes between the hands; fugue entries

Unit 2 Rhythm Against Rhythm
Two against three, three against four, duplets, quintuplets and septuplets, hemiola

Unit 3 Changing Meters, Modes and No Key
Time signatures that change every bar or two; 5/4, 7/8 and 5/8; modes, whole-tone and pentatonic scal

Unit 4 Chromatic Harmony
Diminished sevenths, secondary dominants of every degree, the Neapolitan sixth, augmented sixths, enh

Unit 5 Big Textures
Octaves in both hands, full chords with the tune on top, 8va and 8vb signs, three-staff piano writing, ha

Unit 6 Accompanying
Three staves: a voice (or violin) line above the piano; introductions and interludes; following the soloist

Unit 7 Open Score, C Clefs and Transposing
Four staves (SATB), the treble clef with an 8 below, the alto clef (viola) and the tenor clef (cello, bassoon)

Unit 8 Lead Sheets, Simplifying and Review
Chord symbols (C, Am7, G7/B, Fmaj7, Bdim, C/E); realising a lead sheet; review of the whole course

Unit 1

Three Voices

New: Three independent voices on two staves; the middle voice passes between the hands; fugue entries

Volumes 1-5 taught you to read piano music. This volume teaches you to read music written for anyone: for three or four independent voices, for a singer and a pianist, for a string quartet, for a band reading from chord symbols. It starts with the hardest kind of piano music to read at sight: three voices at once, as in a Bach sinfonia or fugue.

In three-voice music the right hand usually plays two voices on the upper staff and the left hand plays the bass. But the middle voice goes where it likes: when it comes down, the left hand takes it, and when it goes up, the right hand takes it back. Read each voice as a line, not as a pile of chords.

What is new

Three voices

Two voices share the upper staff: the top one has stems up, the middle one stems down. The bass is alone on the lower staff. Follow each line by its stems and beams; a note held in one voice goes on while another voice moves.

The middle voice changes hands

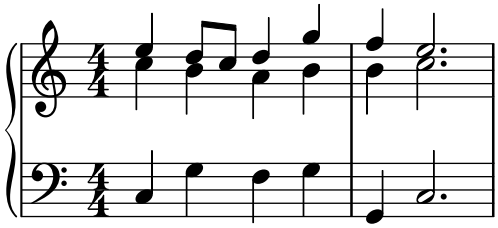
When the middle voice comes down near the bass, it is printed on the lower staff (stems up) and the left hand plays it. Look for a run of notes that moves from one staff to the other: it is one line.

Subject, answer, countersubject

A fugue starts with one voice alone playing a short tune: the subject. Then a second voice plays it a fifth higher (or a fourth lower): the answer, while the first voice goes on with a counter-tune, the countersubject. Then the third voice plays the subject again. Once you know the subject, you can read every entry at a glance.

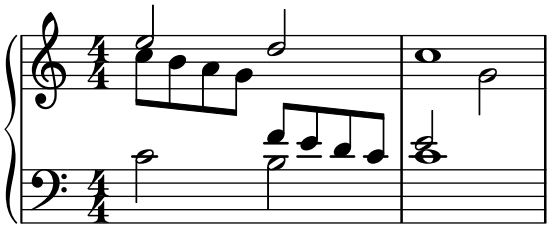
Three voices on two staves

Top voice: stems up. Middle voice: stems down on the same staff. Bass: the lower staff. The top voice moves while the middle one holds, and the other way round.



The middle voice changes hands

The middle voice runs down from the right hand into the left hand (stems up on the lower staff) and comes back up in bar 2. It is one line: play it smoothly across the hands.



A subject and its answer

The subject of the Fugue in G (the last piece in this unit), then the answer a fourth lower. A real answer moves every note by the same distance. This one is a tonal answer: the subject's first note, D (the fifth of G), is answered by G (the tonic), not by A; after that the answer is exact.



Reading tips

1. Before you play, follow each voice through the first two bars with your eyes: top, middle, bass.

2. Stems tell you the voice: on the upper staff, stems up are the top voice and stems down the middle voice.

3. When notes jump from one staff to the other in a beamed group, it is the middle voice changing hands.

4. In a fugue, learn the subject by heart before you start: every new entry is the same tune.

5. Keep held notes held. If a held note is hard, shorten it rather than stop the beat.

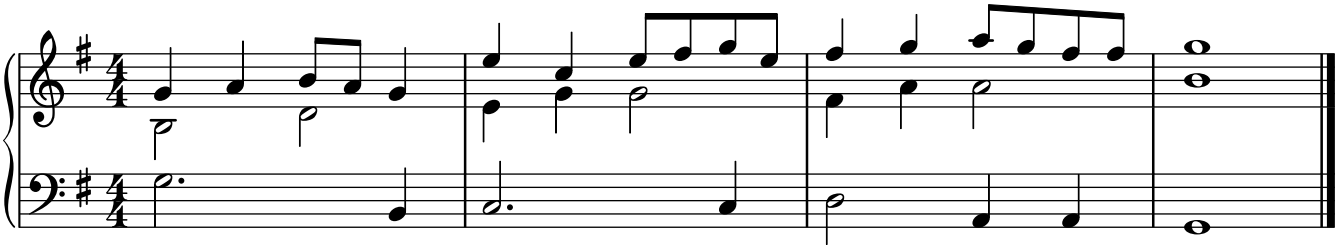
Part A: Three voices: two in the right hand ♩= 60

Three voices: the right hand plays a tune and a middle voice on the upper staff, the left hand a bass. Four bars. C, G, F major and D minor.

☐ **1.1**



☐ **1.2**



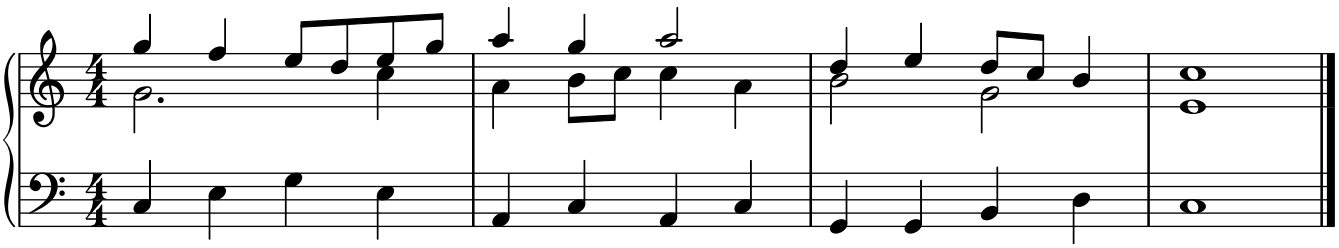
☐ **1.3**



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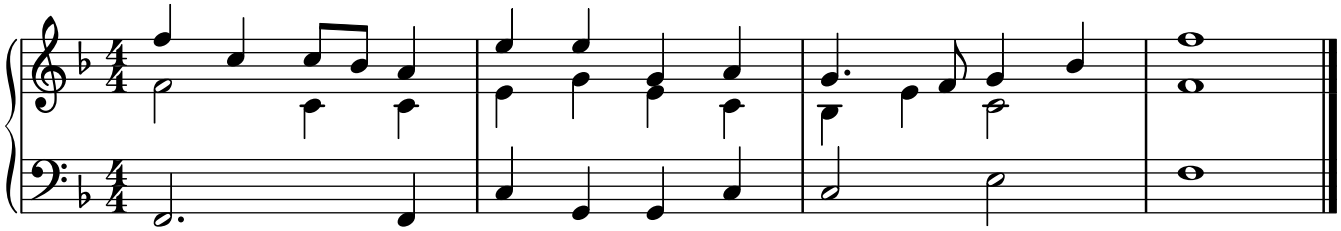
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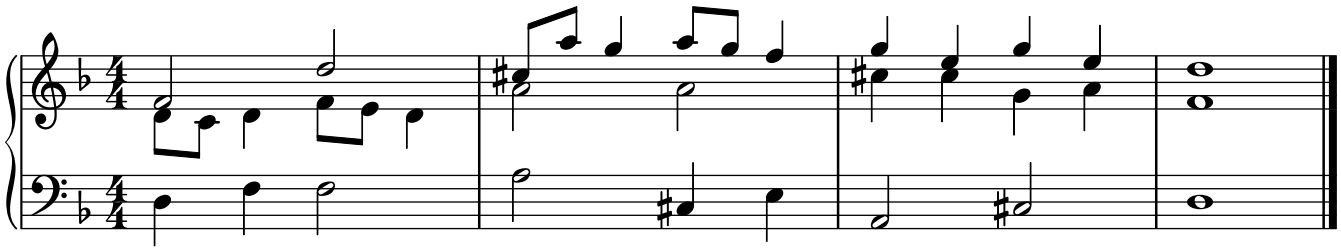
☐ **1.6**



☐ **1.7**



☐ **1.8**



Part B: The middle voice changes hands ♩ = 60

The middle voice changes hands: in some bars it is on the upper staff (right hand), in others on the lower staff (left hand). Eight bars.

☐ **1.9**



☐ **1.10**



☐ **1.11**



☐ **1.12**



☐ **1.13**



☐ **1.14**



☐ **1.15**



1.16

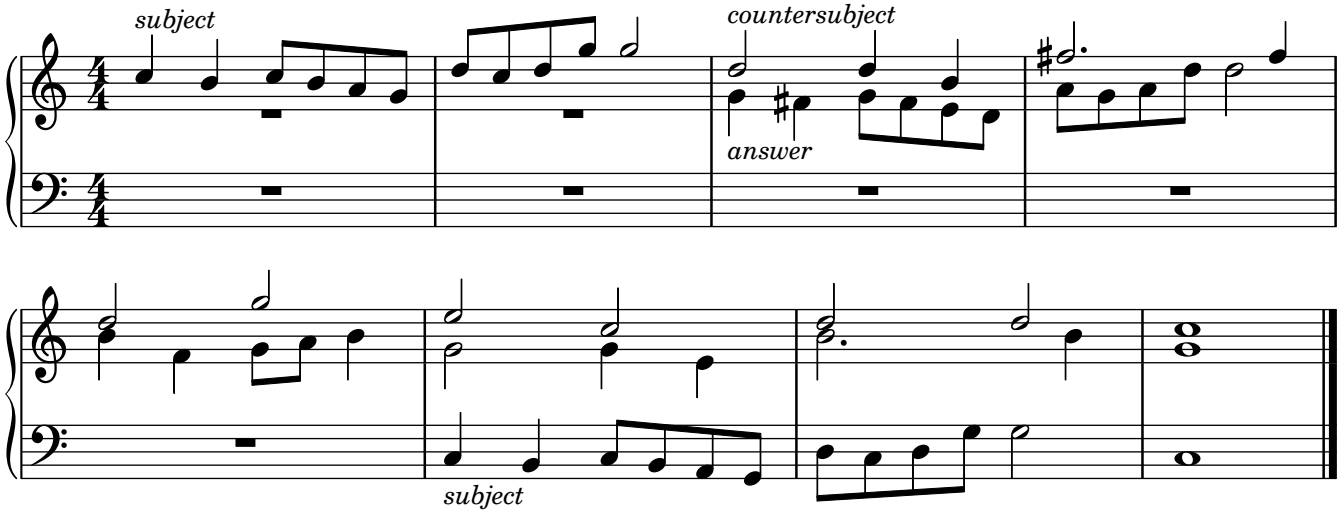


Part C: Fugue entries: subject, answer, countersubject

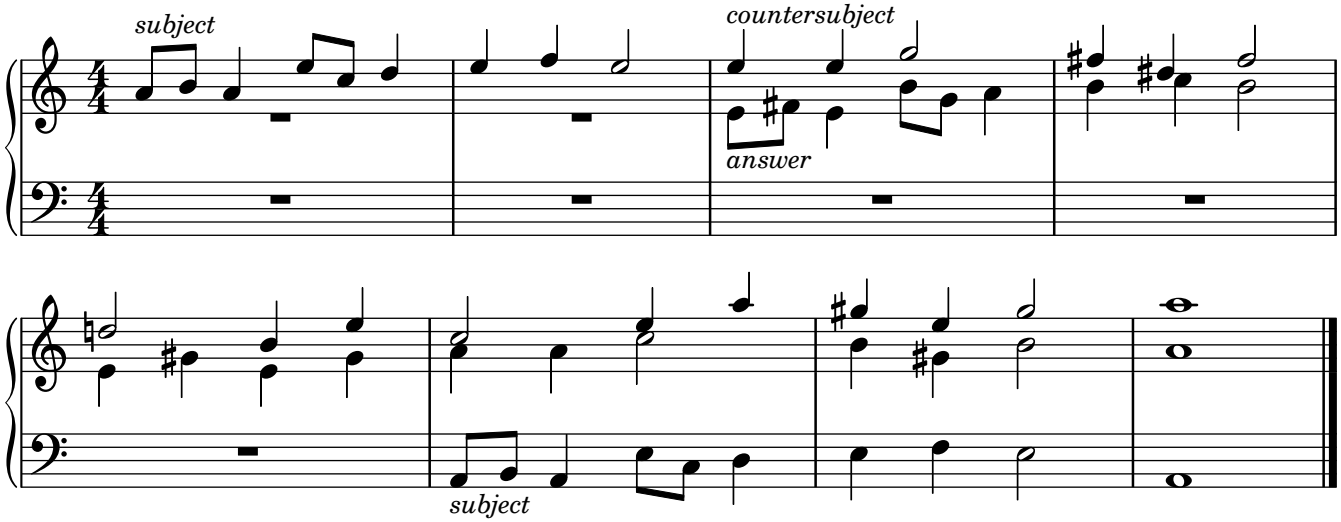
♩ = 56

Fugue entries: the subject in the top voice (bars 1-2), the answer in the middle voice (bars 3-4) with the countersubject above it, a one-bar link, then the subject in the bass (bars 6-7) and the closing chord. The first four exercises label each entry; find them yourself in the others.

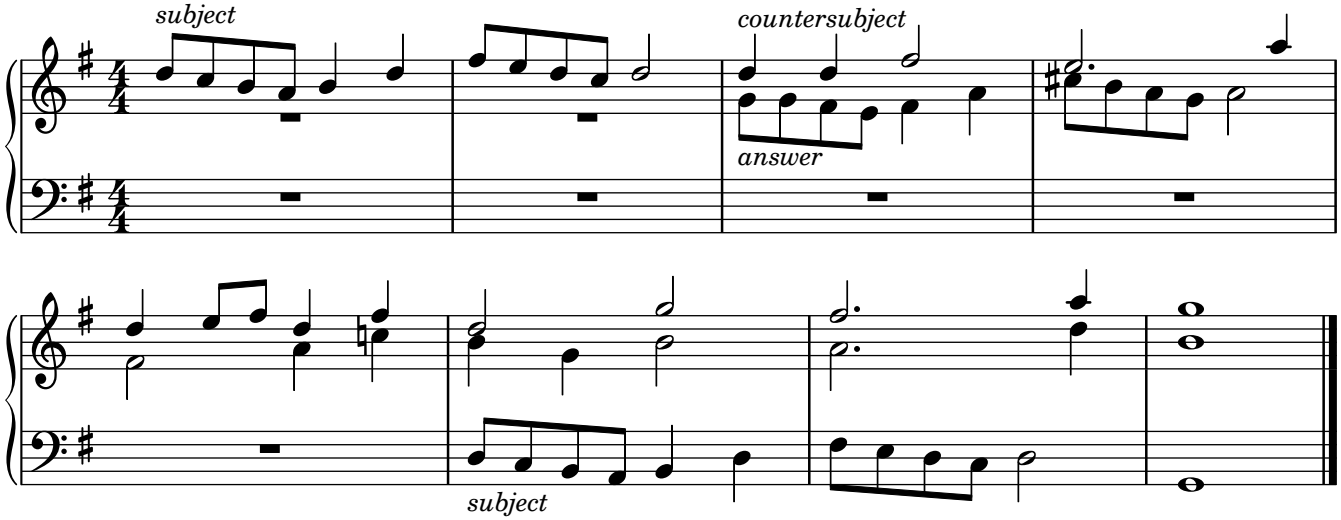
☐ **1.17**



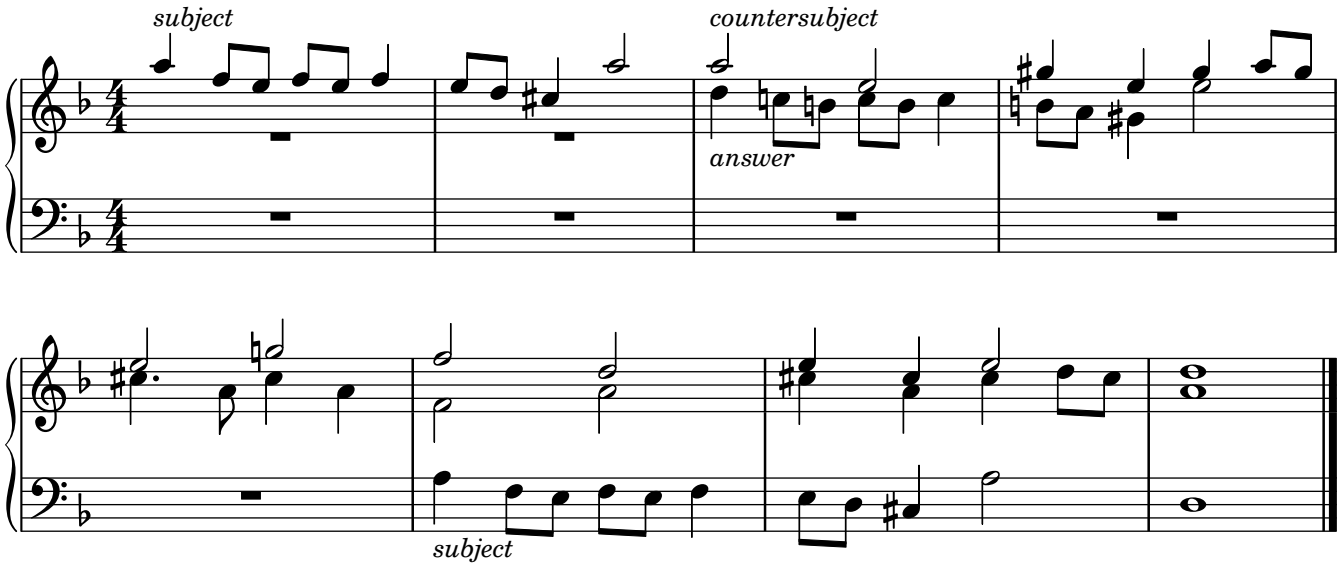
☐ **1.18**



☐ **1.19**



☐ **1.20**



☐ **1.21**



☐ **1.22**



☐ **1.23**



☐ **1.24**



Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Sinfonia No. 1 ♩= 60

J. S. Bach, Sinfonia No. 1 in C, BWV 787 - bars 1-6, with a closing chord

The top voice opens with a rising scale; in bar 2 the middle voice imitates it, starting in the left hand (stems up on the lower staff) and moving up into the right hand. In bar 6 the middle voice runs down into the left hand again and stays there. The bass imitates the scale in bars 3-5. The excerpt ends with a C major chord in place of Bach's bar 7. Source: Mutopia Project no. 142 (public domain).



Sinfonia No. 11 ♩. = 50

J. S. Bach, Sinfonia No. 11 in G minor, BWV 797 - bars 1-16

Three voices in 3/8, one beat in a bar. The top voice starts with a broken G minor chord; one bar later the middle voice copies it a fourth lower, and in bar 8 the bass, two octaves lower. Each time the broken chord runs down, its lowest note may be printed on the lower staff: the left hand takes it. In bar 12 that note is the C the left hand is already holding. Bar 9 has a short trill on B (the zig-zag sign: alternate B and C quickly), finished by two thirty-second notes. The excerpt ends in B-flat major, where Bach's first phrase closes. Source: Mutopia Project no. 200 (public domain).



Fugue in C minor ♩= 60

J. S. Bach, The Well-Tempered Clavier I, Fugue in C minor, BWV 847 - bars 1-8, with a closing chord

The exposition of a famous fugue. The alto plays the subject alone (bars 1-2); the soprano answers it a fifth higher (bars 3-4), a tonal answer: the subject's leap down to G becomes a leap down to C, while the alto plays the countersubject in the left hand, in the treble clef. Bars 5-6 are an episode built from the subject's first notes. In bar 7 the bass enters with the subject and the alto comes back to the right hand. The closing chord (with the bass falling from E-flat to C) is added here; Bach's fugue goes on. Source: Mutopia Project no. 1941 (Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0, typeset by Urs Metzger).



Fugue in G ♩= 60

Original, written for this book

A small fugue made with the rules of Part C. The soprano plays the subject (bars 1-2); the alto answers it a fourth lower with a tonal answer: the subject's first note, D, is answered by G (see the example in this unit), while the soprano plays the countersubject. Bar 5 is a short episode in D major. In bar 6 the bass plays the subject two octaves lower, and bars 8-9 close in G.



Checkpoint

- Play two exercises from Part C a day for a week: name each entry (subject, answer, subject in the bass) before you play, then play without stopping.
- Pass if you can play the Fugue in G and Part B's exercises at sight, steadily, with every held note held, and Sinfonia No. 1 after a few days.